Benjamin Britten

Nocturne

for tenor solo, seven obligato instruments
and string orchestra

Op. 60

Vocal Score by Imogen Holst

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To Alma Mahler

On a poet's lips I slept
Dreaming like a love-adept
In the sound his breathing kept;
Nor seeks nor finds he mortal blisses,
But feeds on the aëreal kisses
Of shapes that haunt thought's wildernesses.
He will watch from dawn to gloom
The lake-reflected sun illume
The yellow bees in the ivy-bloom,
Nor heed nor see, what things they be;
But from these create he can
Forms more real than living man,
Nurslings of immortality!

(*Prometheus Unbound*—SHELLEY)

(Bassoon obligato)

Below the thunders of the upper deep;
Far, far beneath in the absymal sea,
His ancient, dreamless, uninvaded sleep
The Kraken sleepeth: faintest sunlights flee
About his shadowy sides: above him swell
Huge sponges of millennial growth and height;
And far away into the sickly light,
From many a wondrous grot and secret cell
Unnumber'd and enormous polypi
Winnow with giant arms the slumbering green.
There hath he lain for ages and will lie
Battening upon huge seaworms in his sleep,
Until the latter fire shall heat the deep;
Then once by men and angels to be seen,
In roaring he shall rise and on the surface die.

(*The Kraken*—TENNYSON)

(Harp obligato)

Encinctured with a twine of leaves,
That leafy twine his only dress!
A lovely Boy was plucking fruits,
By moonlight, in a wilderness.
The moon was bright, the air was free,
And fruits and flowers together grew
On many a shrub and many a tree:
And all put on a gentle hue,
Hanging in the shadowy air
Like a picture rich and rare.
It was a climate where, they say,
The night is more beloved than day.
But who that beauteous Boy beguiled,
That beauteous Boy to linger here?
Alone, by night, a little child,
In place so silent and so wild—
Has he no friend, no loving mother near?

(*The Wanderings of Cain*—COLERIDGE)

(Horn obligato)

Midnight's bell goes ting, ting, ting, ting, ting,
Then dogs do howl, and not a bird does sing
But the nightingale, and she cries twit, twit, twit;
Owls then on every bough do sit;
Ravens croak on chimneys' tops;
The cricket in the chamber hops;
The nibbling mouse is not asleep,
But he goes peep, peep, peep, peep, peep;
And the cats cry mew, mew, mew,
And still the cats cry mew, mew, mew.

(*Blurt, Master Constable*—MIDDLETON)

(Timpani obligato)

But that night
When on my bed I lay, I was most mov'd
And felt most deeply in what world I was;
With unextinguish'd taper I kept watch,
Reading at intervals; the fear gone by
Press'd on me almost like a fear to come;
I thought of those September Massacres,
Divided from me by a little month,
And felt and touch'd them, a substantial dread:
The rest was conjured up from tragic fictions,
And mournful Calendars of true history,
Remembrances and dim admonishments.
'The horse is taught his manage, and the wind
Of heaven wheels round and treads in his own steps,
Year follows year, the tide returns again,
Day follows day, all things have second birth;
The earthquake is not satisfied at once.'
And in such way I wrought upon myself,
Until I seem'd to hear a voice that cried
To the whole City, 'Sleep no more'.

(*The Prelude* (1805) WORDSWORTH)

(English Horn obligato)

She sleeps on soft, last breaths; but no ghost looms
Out of the stillness of her palace wall,
Her wall of boys on boys and dooms on dooms.

She dreams of golden gardens and sweet glooms,
Not marvelling why her roses never fall
Nor what red mouths were torn to make their blooms.

The shades keep down which well might roam her hall.
Quiet their blood lies in her crimson rooms
And she is not afraid of their footfall.

They move not from her tapestries, their pall,
Nor pace her terraces, their hecatombs,
Lest aught she be disturbed, or grieved at all.

(*The Kind Ghosts*—OWEN)
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(Flute and Clarinet obligato)

What is more gentle than a wind in summer?
What is more soothing than the pretty hummer
That stays one moment in an open flower,
And buzzes cheerily from bower to bower?
What is more tranquil than a musk-rose blowing
In a green island, far from all men's knowing?
More healthful than the leafiness of dales?
More secret than a nest of nightingales?
More serene than Cordelia's countenance?
More full of visions than a high romance?
What, but thee, Sleep? Soft closer of our eyes!
Low murmurer of tender lullabies!
Light hoverer around our happy pillows!
Wreather of poppy buds, and weeping willows!
Silent entangler of a beauty's tresses!
Most happy listener! when the morning blesses
Thee for enlivening all the cheerful eyes
That glance so brightly at the new sun-rise.

(*Sleep and Poetry*—KEATS)

When most I wink, then do mine eyes best see,
For all the day they view things unrespected;
But when I sleep, in dreams they look on thee,
And darkly bright, are bright in dark directed.
Then thou, whose shadow shadows doth make bright,
How would thy shadow's form form happy show
To the clear days with thy much clearer light,
When to unseeing eyes thy shade shines so!
How would, I say, mine eyes be blessed made
By looking on thee in the living day,
When in dead night thy fair imperfect shade
Through heavy sleep on sightless eyes doth stay!
All days are nights to see till I see thee,
And nights bright days when dreams do show thee me.

(*Sonnet* 43—SHAKESPEARE)

The first performance of this work was given on 16th October, 1958, during the Leeds Centenary Festival by Peter Pears with the B.B.C. Symphony Orchestra, conducted by Rudolf Schwarz.

Orchestra

Flute, English Horn, Clarinet, Bassoon,
Horn, Harp and Timpani Solos
String Orchestra

Duration: 25 minutes

To Alma Mahler

NOCTURNE

BENJAMIN BRITTEN
Op. 60



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on the aë-real kiss-es Of shapes ..... that haunt..... thought's wil -
- der - nes-ses.
(ppp)
p
1
p
He will watch from dawn to gloom The lake - re - flect - ed
(pizz.)
sun... il - lume The yel - low bees in the i - vy - bloom,
sf


p
Nor heed nor see,... what things they be; .....
(always ppp)
2
p
But from these..... cre-ate he can.....
Forms more re-al than liv - ing man,


p
Nurs - - - lings of
8va
dying away
im-mor-tal - - i - ty, of im-mor-tal - - - - - i -
8
- ty!
Bassoon obligato
pizz.
pp
ff
sf
ffz
ppp
ppp smooth
pp
ff
ffz
ppp smooth
accel. - - - -
3 Majestic (slightly faster = 69)
(freely)
pp
cresc.
ffz
ff
sustained


Be - low the thunders of the
up-per deep; ..... Far, far..... be - neath... in the a - bys - mal sea,...
..... His an - cient, dream - less, un - in-vad-ed sleep The
Kra - ken sleepeth, the Kra - - - ken sleep-eth, sleep -
4
dim.


- eth:
faint - est sun - lights flee A -
express.
p marked
- bout his sha-dow-y sides:
a - bove him
swell Huge spon - ges
of..... mil - len - nialgrowthand
5
height;
And far a - way in - to the sick - ly


light, From ma-ny a won-drous grot..... and se-cret
sliding
cell Un-num- -ber'd and e-
-nor- mous po-ly-pi Win- now with gi-ant
cresc.
arms the slum-ber-ing green.....


6
f
There hath he lain for a - ges... and will lie..... Bat-ten-ing up-
fz
ff
f
3
p
5
sustained
-on huge sea - worms in his sleep,.... Un - til.....
.....
the lat - ter fire..... shall heat the deep; Then
cresc.
once by men and an-gels to be seen, In


roar - ing he shall rise and on the sur - face.....
p
f
ff
p
die.
ppp
pp
dim.
rall.-
Ped.
7 as at the start
ppp very smooth
ppp
always ppp
Ped.
ppp
8
sfp
pp
Ped.
Ped.
8 Slow waltz (♩= 76-80)
Harp obligato
sfpp
p clearly
ppp
(with ped.)


cresc.
fpp
p
pp
pp
9
lightly
En - cinc - - - - tured.....
with a twine ..... of leaves,
That leaf - y twine his on - - - ly dress!.....


.....
A love - ly..... Boy was
cresc.
fpp
pluck - ing fruits,
By moon-light, in a
wild-er-ness.
p smooth
The
pp
10
moon ..... was bright, the air ..... was free, And
pp


fruits and flowers..... to - ge - - - - ther grew On
ma - ny a shrub and ma - - ny a tree: And all.....
..... put on a gen - - tle hue,..... Hang - ing
in the sha - - dowy air Like..... a pic - -


11
pp
- ture rich..... and rare.
It was a cli - mate
ppp
where, they say, The night is more be - loved..... than
day.
gliss. (white)
7
cresc. molto
f
But who..... that beau-teous Boy..... be-guiled,
p.
That beau-teous
sfp
Vla.
ppp


Boy to lin - ger here? A - lone, by night, a lit - tle
pp
12
pp
child, In place..... so si - lent, and..
pp
..... so ..... wild_ .....
Gliss. (white)
6
13 as at the start
f
pp
Has he no friend, no lov-ing mo - ther near?
sfp
Vla.
ppp
very smooth


pp
Midnight's bell goes ting, ting,
pp
Horn obligato
pp
Ped.
pp
Ped.
..... ting, ... ting, ting, Then dogs do
Horn
pp
howl, and not a bird..... does sing But the night-in-gale,..... and she cries
pp
dim.
pp
twit, twit, twit, twit, twit; Owls then on
mf
Horn
12
p


marked
ev-ery bough do sit;...
Ra-vens croak on chimneys tops;
Horn
6
pp
14
short
The cricket in the chamber hops;
(Horn trem.)
pp
p
The nibbling mouse.... is not a - sleep,..... But he goes peep, peep,
pp
ppp
pp
peep, peep, peep, peep,
And the cats cry
expressive
mew!..... mew!
ppp
Horn
mf


mew! ..... mew!
And still the cats cry
ppp
express.
mew! ..... mew!
dim.
mew! ..... mew!
dying away
mew! ..... mew!
mf
dying away
15 Steady march (♩ = 72)
pppp
ppp
Timpani obligato
always marked
dark
But that night When
dim.
ppp


on my bed I lay, I was most mov'd And
express.
ppp
felt most deep - ly in what world I was; With
ppp
3
pp
un-extinguish'd ta - per I kept watch, Read-ing at in - tervals;
3
3
ppp
16
the fear gone by Press'd on me almost like ..... a
fpp
ppp
3
fpp


fear to come; I thought of those Sep - tem - ber
fpp
fpp
Massacres, Di - vi - ded from me by a lit-tle month,
dim.
f
p
And felt, and touch'd them, a sub-stan-tial
dim.
dim.
17
dread; The rest was con-jur'd up
p
pp little by little cresc.
(p)
(p)


from tra-gic fic - tions,
And mourn - ful Ca-len-dars
of true ..... his-to-ry,
Re-membrances and
dim ..... ad - mon-ish-ments. 'The
18
horse is taught his manage, and the wind Of heav'n wheels round, wheels round..... and


treads in his own steps,
cresc.
f
sf
f
Year..... fol - lows year,..... the tide returns again, Day follows
f
mf
pp
f
p
day,..... all things have se - cond birth,.....
f
mf
cresc.
mf
ff ad lib.
The earthquake is not sat - is - fied..... at
ff
ppp
(as if trills)
sf
f
sf

19 in time (animated)

intense

once! And in such way..... I wrought up -

ppp (*ppp*) (*ppp*)

mf *f* *pp* *f*

- on my - self,..... Un - til I seem'd to hear a

pp *mf* *f* *pp* *cresc.*

voice that cried..... To the whole

f

(♩= 60) *ff declaimed* strictly in time

Ci-ty,..... 'Sleep no more!'

mf *ffz* *fff* *dim.*

mf *f*


20 Slow and regular (♩ = ♩. of preceding = 40)
English Horn obligato
express.
p
(pizz.)
without pedal
pp very smooth
She sleeps on soft, last breaths;
but no ghost looms Out..... of the still - ness of her pa-lace
wall, Her wall of boys on boys and dooms on dooms.


21
She dreams of gol-den gar - dens and sweet glooms,.....
Not
a little cresc.
marvelling why her ro - ses ne-ver fall.....
rather f
Nor what red mouths were
a little cresc.
mf
torn to make their blooms.....
pp
The
f
dim.
pp
pp.
22
shades keep down which well might roam her hall.
(p)
Quiet
their
pp calmly


pp
blood lies in her crim - - son rooms And
pp'
she is not a-fraid of their foot-fall.
pp
express.
23
p
They move not from her ta-pes-tries, their pall,
p
softer
Nor pace..... her ter-ra-ces, their hec-a-tombs,
pp


pp
Lest aught she..... be dis-turbed, or..... grieved at all.
ppp
ppp
dying away
24 as at the start
Strings ppp very smooth
pp
(Db.) ppp
Ped.
(Vla.) pp
Ped.
(Db.)
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
Ped.
(attacca)
25
Quick (♩ = 120)
p
What is more gen -
(rubato)
Flute obligato sim.
(in time)
p
sim.


- tle than a wind in sum - mer?
26
Clarinet obligato
What is more sooth -
- ing than the pret-ty hum - mer That stays one mo - ment
in an o - pen flow - er, And buz - zes cheer - i - ly from
bower to bow - er?
27
Fl.


p
(pp)
What is more tran - quil than a musk-rose blow - ing In a green is - land,
far from all men's know - ing?
mf
More
f
Cl.
health - ful than the leaf - i - ness of dales?.....
28
p
More se - cret than a nest of night - in-gales?
Fl.
pp


p
More se -
Fl.
ppp
f
Cl.
pp
29
- rene
than Cor - de - lia's coun - ten-ance?
pp
ppp
cresc.
f
More full of
f marked
vis - ions than a high ro - mance?


quietly
What but thee, what..... but thee,..... what but
Fl.
p
Cl.
(no rall.)
pp
30
thee, what but thee, Sleep? Soft
Str.
ppp
p
clo - ser, clo - ser of our..... eyes! Low
ppp
p
slow (as at the start)
31
quick (as before)
mur - mur-er of ten - der lul - la - bies!... Light
ppp
pp


ho - ver - er a - round our hap - py pil - lows! Wreath - er of pop-py buds, and
slow (as before)
32
quick (as before)
weep - ing..... wil - lows!
Si - lent en-tang - ler of a
rall. - - - in time
beau - - ty's..... tres - ses!
Most hap - py, hap - py
33
slow (as before)
express.
list-en-er!.. when the morn - ing bless-es Thee for en - live - ning
pp very smooth
(etc.)

34

dim.

pp

all the cheerful eyes That glance so bright - ly at the new sun rise.

Bsn. Harp

pp

pp

rall.

+ Clt.

pp

pp

+ Fl. E.H.

p

(pizz.)

pp

ppp

Timp.

mf

ppp

35 Slow (♩= 72-80)

p

When most I wink, then do mine eyes best see, For...

Str. solos

pp express. but marked

Wind Harp

..... all the day they view things un - re - spect-ed;

pp cresc.

sustained


But when I sleep, in dreams they look on thee,..... And
f
36
dark - ly bright, are bright in dark di - rect-ed.
p
cresc.
f
Then thou,..... whose sha-dow.... sha-dows doth make bright,
p
mf
dim.
p
pp
f
pp clearly
How would thy sha-dow's form form hap-py show To the clear days
pp


with thy much clear - er light,
When to un - see - ing eyes
W.W.
Harp
pp
(always pp)
37
pp
always crescendo
thy shade shines so!
How would, I say, mine eyes be
ppp
(Str. tutti)
express.
always crescendo
blessed made..... By look-ing on thee in the liv-ing day,
38
When in dead night thy fair im - per - fect shade
mf cresc.
f cresc.



[Aldeburgh– Summer, 1958]